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PRINCE KAPOOR, 29, is the quintessential young Indian entrepreneur, bouncing with ambition and ideas. A little over three years ago, the Co-founder of Chennai-based start-up Push got on to Google Display Network (or GDN, which are ads that show up on articles, websites and videos that consumers browse). Estimated to reach over 90 per cent of internet users, GDN allows ads to reach their audience at various points—while they surf the internet, watch a video, or even view emails. It is a cost-effective option known to work well for brands, especially those with limited budgets. “This was a better way to allocate capital,” says Kapoor, whose firm sells women’s health and wellness products. “GDN is very cost-effective and delivers more bang for the buck.” Thanks to its affordable nature, practically anyone from the neighbourhood *kirana* store to big companies can be on GDN, where space is unlimited, and so is the extent to which innovation is possible.

For Google, however, GDN is a small part of what it does in India, think search, YouTube, affordable handsets, Google Pay, cloud, SMEs... the list is long. In turn, India is a very small part of Google globally. Munch this: Google India ended FY22 with revenues of ₹9,286 crore (about \$1.14 billion at current exchange rates). That was a massive rise of 45 per cent from FY21. Net profit, at ₹1,239 crore, was up 53 per cent. Now let’s look at the global picture. Google’s parent, Alphabet, ended 2021 (calendar

year) with revenues of \$258 billion, and net profits of \$76 billion.

That means India is less than 0.5 per cent of Google’s global top line. Normally, that would make the country rather unattractive to any firm that has been here for the 19 years that Google has. But for Google, India is hugely strategic. That explains the 2020 announcement of a \$10-billion Google for India Digitization Fund. In a blog, CEO Sundar Pichai had outlined four key investment areas for this fund—enabling affordable internet access in local languages; building products suited to India’s unique needs; empowering businesses in their digital transformation journeys; and leveraging technology and AI for social good. “This commitment underlines our confidence and recognition of India’s growing role in the global technological space,” says Sanjay Gupta, Google India’s Country Head and Vice President. “We have not done this before at this scale in any other country.”

But as Google seeks to step on the gas in India, it will have to deal with several challenges. In India, it has been fined ₹1,337.76 crore by the Competition Commission of India (CCI) for abuse of Android’s dominant position, a decision upheld by the Supreme Court (more on that later). Globally, it sacked 12,000 employees recently, as it reviews its priorities in an economic environment that is gasping for growth. Not to mention a possible threat to the core of its vast empire—search—from a new AI tech called ChatGPT.

THERE’S MUCH ACTION and energy at Google’s India office in Mumbai’s buzzing BKC business district. An eclectic mix of retro and modern characterises the office and the walls are adorned with one-liners in Hinglish,

THE GOOGLE GAME PLAN

- 1 **Google India’s businesses include Search, YouTube, Maps, affordable handsets, Google Pay (GPay), Cloud and SMEs**
- 2 **For India, it has created Maps in offline mode, Files by Google, YouTube offline and GPay**
- 3 **The \$10-billion Google for India Digitization Fund is important since the tech major has not committed an investment of this scale in any other country**
- 4 **AI is a significant foray in India since it will cut through key areas such as agriculture, healthcare and education**
- 5 **The next big offering is Pixel, and Google is looking to get a share of the handset market after dominating the operating system market with Android**

provoking laughter. In this informal environment, where ‘casual’ is the buzzword, Gupta looks slightly incongruous in his formal attire (in a blazer but without a tie). But then, one would expect that from someone who spent most of his career in industries like FMCG (at Hindustan Unilever), telecom (Bharti Airtel) and entertainment (then Star India).

“Our core strategy is about two words—inclusion and trust. We want to make the internet helpful and safe for a billion Indians,” says Gupta, 55, who joined the tech giant in early 2020. On inclusion, the ob-